

Tokyo Games: Robot Zen Garden inspired by athletes.

BBC, Tech, Paul Carter, 08/24/2021, 3min2s

1. For which event was the artwork created?

⇒ And for this year's Olympics and Paralympics in Tokyo

2. What was the artwork inspired by?

⇒ an artwork inspired by traditional Japanese Zen gardens.

3. What's the name of the project?

⇒ "Constant gardeners"

4. How many entrants participated in the competition?

⇒ 2400 other entrants

5. The robot's movements are inspired by athletes' performances.

☒ True ☐ False

6. Where was the art installation sent from?

☐ Japan.
☒ The United Kingdom.
☐ The United States of America.

7. Other than video clips, what did the team work from?

⇒ we've also worked with some numerical data, results data,
be that speeds or times or heights or distances

8. Marie McPartlin ...

☐ isn't convinced by technology.
☒ questions the access to technology.
☐ thinks that everybody can access technology.

9. The more we use technology in our day-to-day lives, the more it will rise in the creative realm.

☒ True ☐ False

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Since 2002, Jason Bruges studio has been pushing the boundaries of art installation by using a high-tech mixed media pallet to create interactive spaces.

And for this year's Olympics and Paralympics in Tokyo, the team has created an artwork inspired by traditional Japanese Zen gardens.

- One of the great things about the artwork is that it is designed to be experienced in person and in the round². But it is not until you get this up close in person that you really get a sense of the scale.

The project called "Constant gardeners" is a result of an open competition with the arts council of Tokyo and the Tokyo metropolitan government. Their idea was selected out of 2400 other entrants and it's paying homage to the athletes by representing their performances.

- So we're looking at footage from different sports subtracting and extracting movement out of it, frame by frame. We are then doing pose estimation, which essentially draws out different elements of that movement and then applying that to an algorithm that then drives our artistic representation of that in the robot's movements.

The art installation was shipped from the UK right into the heart of Ueno Park to create over 150 unique illustrations to run alongside the games until September.

- We are working mainly from video clips, but we've also worked with some numerical data, results data, be that speeds or times or heights or distances.
- I think there is no doubt that technology opens up lots of potential in the arts. But one of the big barriers really is who can access the technology in the first place, be it hardware or software. A lot of the stuff that is needed for that is actually being generated in the commercial sector, in film, in architecture, in the videogame world, so there still remains some barriers around who can actually access the technology to make the work.

But if you can overcome the price point and get the necessary expertise, it's just another tool for artistic expression.

- To me, it's a kind of story and the narrative is particularly important. It'd be like critiquing a new type of paint or a kind of new type of fabrication. All the robotics are helping us tell this story effectively, but at the same time, people are worried about their jobs, the future. I think if you start applying and testing technology in places like the arts and culture, you can open up conversations about those opportunities and positives.

Whether or not you are a fan of the arts or robotics, the "Constant Gardeners" have offered a different kind of celebration of the Tokyo games. And as technology becomes increasingly important in our day-to-day lives, it will continue to rise in the creative realm³ too.

² In the round: that we can go around.

³ Realm : field, domain, area.